

4.1.3 Transport in cells

4.1.3.1 Diffusion

Content	Key opportunities for skills development
Substances may move into and out of cells across the cell membranes via diffusion. Diffusion is the spreading out of the particles of any substance in solution, or particles of a gas, resulting in a net movement from an area of higher concentration to an area of lower concentration. Some of the substances transported in and out of cells by diffusion are oxygen and carbon dioxide in gas exchange, and of the waste product urea from cells into the blood plasma for excretion in the kidney. Students should be able to explain how different factors affect the rate of diffusion. Factors which affect the rate of diffusion are: • the difference in concentrations (concentration gradient) • the temperature • the surface area of the membrane. A single-celled organism has a relatively large surface area to volume ratio. This allows sufficient transport of molecules into and out of the cell to meet the needs of the organism.	WS 1.2 Recognise, draw and interpret diagrams that model diffusion. WS 1.5 Use of isotonic drinks and high energy drinks in sport.
Students should be able to calculate and compare surface area to volume ratios. Students should be able to explain the need for exchange surfaces and a transport system in multicellular organisms in terms of surface area to volume ratio. Students should be able to explain how the small intestine and lungs in mammals, gills in fish, and the roots and leaves in plants, are adapted for exchanging materials. In multicellular organisms, surfaces and organ systems are specialised for exchanging materials. This is to allow sufficient molecules to be transported into and out of cells for the organism's needs. The effectiveness of an exchange surface is increased by: • having a large surface area • a membrane that is thin, to provide a short diffusion path • (in animals) having an efficient blood supply • (in animals, for gaseous exchange) being ventilated.	MS 1c, 5c

4.1.3.2 Osmosis

Content	Key opportunities for skills development
Water may move across cell membranes via osmosis. Osmosis is the diffusion of water from a dilute solution to a concentrated solution through a partially permeable membrane.	WS 1.2 Recognise, draw and interpret diagrams that model osmosis.
Students should be able to: • use simple compound measures of rate of water uptake • use percentages • calculate percentage gain and loss of mass of plant tissue.	MS 1a, 1c
Students should be able to plot, draw and interpret appropriate graphs.	MS 4a, 4b, 4c, 4d

Required practical activity 2: investigate the effect of a range of concentrations of salt or sugar solutions on the mass of plant tissue.

AT skills covered by this practical activity: biology AT 1, 3 and 5.

This practical activity also provides opportunities to develop WS and MS. Details of all skills are given in [Key opportunities for skills development](#) (page 176).

4.1.3.3 Active transport

Content	Key opportunities for skills development
Active transport moves substances from a more dilute solution to a more concentrated solution (against a concentration gradient). This requires energy from respiration. Active transport allows mineral ions to be absorbed into plant root hairs from very dilute solutions in the soil. Plants require ions for healthy growth. It also allows sugar molecules to be absorbed from lower concentrations in the gut into the blood which has a higher sugar concentration. Sugar molecules are used for cell respiration. Students should be able to: • describe how substances are transported into and out of cells by diffusion, osmosis and active transport • explain the differences between the three processes.	There are links with this content to Cell specialisation (page 22).